for me personally, Operation Azalea ended in both massive triumph and failure,' Khurana said.

Illusions of a Relationship

In the early 1970s, the R&AW corridors were abuzz with whispers that the CIA had helped the Indian intelligence agency tackle an external influence fanning the Naxalite movement in West Bengal. A shadowy US operative at the US consulate in Calcutta had 'unofficially' helped the Indian agency in stopping the arms and money from flowing into Indian territory from abroad.

It is true that the R&AW and the CIA have collaborated on several occasions when the issue was of mutual concern. Many serving and retired R&AW officials have said so. The CIA and the US government, in fact, had provided the R&AW with sophisticated surveillance equipment to fight left-wing extremism because they hated communists the most. When the R&AW, sometime in 1972, reported that arms could be coming from Chinese territory, the USA helped the spy agency deploy a surveillance and state of the art communication network along India's border with China. The relationship bloomed when the Intelligence Bureau (IB) was the sole Indian spy agency and in the aftermath of the Indo-Chinese war, the CIA came a little closer to India. But there has always been the suspicion that the Americans are watching their own interests and a partnership with India is decided on the basis of the pound of flesh the CIA could extract. One such incident was the installation of a nuclear-powered monitoring station at the Nanda Devi peaks in the Himalayas to spy on China's atomic tests and missile programme.